Chapter Ten

Aftermath

"We as Jews, have caused what we historically have suffered; a refugee population in Diaspora."

—Martin Buber

For the Palestinian people, the armistice agreements that ended the war brought little comfort. Of approximately 1.2 million Arabs living under British rule in Mandatory Palestine up to May 14, 1948, around 750,000 fled from their homes during the war and from Israeli territory in its aftermath. Many of these refugees crossed the borders into Egypt, Jordan, Lebanon, and Syria, where they were housed in what were planned to be temporary camps. Few were offered citizenship in the countries to which they fled and, incredibly, many of the refugee camps first established in 1948 still exist today in Jordan, Syria, and Lebanon and in the Gaza Strip and the West Bank.

In 1948, the United Nations formed the Relief and Works Agency (UNRWA) specifically to help maintain the 58 official refugee camps and to care for the Palestinians displaced by the war. Today, these camps house the descendants of those originally displaced by the 1948 war and subsequent conflicts. There are now believed to be over 5 million Palestinians living either in refugee camps or in Arab countries. They still have no nation to which they can return, and their plight is a continuing source of concern not just in the Arab world but the international community as a whole.

There was an attempt to create independent Palestinian territory in the aftermath of the 1948 war in the Gaza Strip (an area on the shores of the Mediterranean Sea just 25 miles (40 kilometers) long and 6 miles (20 kilometers) deep) and the West Bank. However, both these areas would be occupied by Israel during the Six-Day War in 1967. The building of Israeli settlements in both the Gaza Strip and